The Future of the Internet Is Under Greater Threat Than Ever Before—and Activists Say the U.S. Needs to Step In

By Billy Perrigo
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The future of the Internet is under greater threat than ever before from authoritarian governments, according to literary and human rights group PEN America, which called on the world's democracies to unite to defend freedom of expression online. Repressive governments are imposing new regulations that invoke "digital sovereignty," but in reality can be used for censorship, surveillance and crackdowns on dissent, PEN America warns in a new report published Tuesday.

In its earliest days, cyberspace was like the Wild West, with no way for governments to enforce national laws, and very few even trying. But as the Internet's impact on society has grown, so have efforts to regulate the negative effects it can have on individuals and societies. Many democratic governments around the world are grappling with laws to mitigate privacy risks, disinformation and hate speech, often making the argument that national laws must also apply online, known as digital sovereignty. But authoritarians, PEN America warns, are using similar rhetoric to consolidate their own power.

States crack down on digital freedoms

The practice extends beyond traditional authoritarian states like Russia or China, whose "great firewall" is a longstanding example of how governments can attempt to control what their citizens see online. Smaller countries like Belarus and Myanmar are increasingly adopting similar approaches. And democratic states like India and Nigeria are using the argument for digital sovereignty to mask repressive crackdowns on freedom of expression, PEN America says.

On June 4, the Nigerian government banned Twitter nationwide after the platform removed a post from President Muhammadu Buhari for what it said was a violation of its rules. And in April, the Indian government forced Twitter and Facebook to remove dozens of posts critical of its handling of the COVID-19 pandemic, citing national law.

Analysts and advocates have stepped up their concerns that moves toward digital sovereignty could lead to internet fragmentation, the report says, adding that: "The ability of writers, journalists, and others to communicate across national boundaries will be subject to political diktats, online communities will fracture, and a new toolbox for state repression will open."

So far, it has been left to the technology companies to push back, with limited success. Twitter has posted records of the takedowns ordered by the Indian government to a public database. After an earlier incident in February, it said that it had refused to take action on some of the tweets belonging to politicians, journalists and activists "because we do not believe that the actions we have been directed to take are consistent with Indian law." In May, Indian police visited the Twitter office in New Delhi after the social media platform labeled several tweets by ruling party members as "manipulated media."

Calls for a new approach

Democratic governments must do more to stand up for online free expression, the PEN America report argues. "We're calling for a renewed and more muscular commitment to democratic digital multilateralism," Tager says. "A coalition of democracies should be developing new digital standards for the future of the Internet."

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